

Lesson 10

Allowing (Part 2) - How to Practice Allowing in Real Moments

In the last lesson, we talked about what allowing is and what it isn't. This one is about how to actually do it. Before we do that though, I want to give you a quick reminder of the difference. Acceptance is being okay with what's here. It's mentally softening toward your situation, but allowing is choosing to let it be.

It's actively giving this sensation or symptom or thought or feeling permission to exist right now. This lesson is about how to do that second part, what it looks like in real moments, what to do when a sensation spikes and how to spot when you're not actually allowing. When a sensation shows up, here's what allowing looks like.

It's very simple. You notice it. You acknowledge that it's there. You don't pretend that it's not happening, and then you do a very quick check in with your body. This is not step by step something that you need to turn into a ritual. Okay? This is just something you do very quickly. Just determine, are you bracing?

Are you starting to tighten up and hold your breath? You probably are, because that kicks in automatically when something uncomfortable shows up. But then you soften. You don't force yourself to relax. That's not gonna be accessible to you right now. We just wanna release that grip, that physical grip a little bit.

Then you leave it alone. You do not start problem solving or analyze what it means. You don't try to figure out what to do about it. You just let it be there. And then you keep doing whatever you were doing. You do not keep stopping your life to manage sensations. You let them be in the background while you continue, so you notice it, you soften, you leave it alone, and you keep going.

It is very simple, but it is not going to feel easy because your brain is going to want to do something. Remember, like these things popping up sends a signal to the brain to jump into action. Your brain is going to want to engage. It's going to tell you that you need to figure this out right now, and your job here is a weird job.

Your job is to not listen to that. Let me show you the contrast between allowing and not allowing, because I want you to see this clearly. Here's what you've probably been doing. A sensation shows up and your brain immediately goes into alarm mode automatically. Duh. That's going to happen. It's gonna say, what is this?

Why is this happening? Is it getting worse? What do I need? Do here, and that is when your body starts tensing up, you start bracing against the sensation. You start problem solving. You're mentally running through everything it could be. It becomes the center of your attention. You get tunnel vision, your body braces because you are in full reaction mode.

That's not allowing, that's what we want to stop doing. That's what that's reacting. That's the automatic reaction that your body has when something uncomfortable shows up. But now imagine that same sensation shows up and yeah, you hate it, but you notice it. You acknowledge that it's there, and then you just let it be there.

You don't clench and brace around it. You don't start the mental spiral. You don't drop everything to figure it out. You notice it. You acknowledge, Hey, this is what's here for me, and you feel it and you keep doing whatever you were doing that's allowing. Let it be there. Whatever it is, let it be. The sensation is the same in both of those scenarios.

The difference is the response. The second one is what allowing actually is. That's what we wanna be constantly moving toward again and again, because every single time you have that second response, instead of the first, you're rewiring your brain. You are teaching your nervous system that a sensation does not require an emergency response, so you're breaking the automatic loop.

That loop that says sensation drives fear, which drives more sensation, which drives more fear. When you break that loop, your default starts to change over time. The phrase that helped me the most was leave it alone. A thought shows up, leave it alone, a sensation arises, leave it alone. Pain spikes, leave it alone.

You don't engage, you don't add anything on top of it. I want you to be able to spot when you're not actually allowing, because you might think you are when you are not. The first thing you may be doing is waiting and watching. So if you are monitoring the sensation and checking over and over again to see if it's getting better, waiting for it to be over, that's not allowing.

It will pass if you let it. It will shift if you let it, but you can't be watching it constantly and waiting for it to pass. You have to take your attention off of it. Let it be in the background. I know that's gonna be hard at first, but as with everything, the more you practice, the better you get. So don't expect to be good right away.

Expect to be bad, but in time you will progress toward this. The second thing is white knuckling through it. That's not allowing, if, if you're gritting your teeth through it and you're super tense and you're holding your breath and you're just like trying to survive until it's over, that's not allowing, that is similar to enduring and, and even fighting, you know, real allowing includes the physical softening.

The third thing is suppressing or ignoring, like if you are pretending the sensation isn't there, pushing it away, distracting yourself so you don't have to feel it or reaching for some tool to make it go away. That's not allowing either. Anything where your underlying goal is to make it go away is not fully allowing.

There's resistance there. Real allowing means you acknowledge it's there, but you don't engage with it. And the fourth is something you're gonna be tempted to do, which is to use, allowing as your new tool, your new strategy. We can turn anything into a tool, just like we've turned everything else into a tool.

If you are allowing because you think this will make the sensation finally go away faster. Unfortunately that's also not allowing, you are still trying to control the outcome. Real allowing doesn't have an agenda. It's not looking for anything specific to happen, especially immediately. So the work with allowing is noticing yourself falling out of allowing or falling into panic and fighting and softening again and again.

Some common mistakes that people make with allowing are, you know, turning it into a protocol. Like I know some people recommend doing, allowing sessions throughout the day, like scheduled times to sit and allow, but in my experience, that just turns it into another thing to do perfectly. The truth is that there are plenty of opportunities to allow through your day.

'cause it's anytime you feel a sensation, a symptom, a feeling, a scary thought. So use those. You don't need a scheduled practice, but you do need to be practicing this multiple times a day. The second thing is expecting it to feel really good, allowing is probably not going to give you relief right away.

It might, but let's just leave it up to we don't know and we are not gonna expect it. It's gonna feel unfamiliar and uncomfortable, especially in the beginning because it's so different to how you've been responding for however long this has been going on. That's okay. The third thing is doing it once and thinking you're done or thinking it.

It didn't work. It is not something you do one time or a couple of times. It's something that you return to again and again throughout the day. And the fourth thing is being really hard on yourself. When you don't allow, or you feel like you're not allowing right or perfectly, but you are not going to do this perfectly, you're going to react sometimes the automatic part of your brain, especially being so sensitized.

It's going to react, and sometimes you're not gonna catch it. You're gonna fall into old behaviors. You're going to begin engaging with thoughts. You're going to join Facebook groups again, you're gonna hop on Reddit and see if anyone has experienced it. You're going to tense up and stay tense for long periods of time.

When that happens, just get back to it. Just start again. No judgment. At some point, allowing stops being just about sensations. You get to this point where you start allowing life back in, doing things again, going places, being present, even with the symptoms still there, taking them with you instead of waiting for them to leave.

And we're gonna get there. But first there's something else that I want to address because you can do all of this. You can stop reacting, build tolerance and capacity, practice acceptance, allow sensations

to be there. And still be incredibly hard on yourself the whole time, and that matters because the way you treat yourself through this process is part of the work too.

That's what we're gonna talk about in the next lesson.

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